

1757



Barbary pirates in an engagement with the Venetian navy.

THE BRITISH-PRUSSIAN ALLIANCE

(see 1756) received a number of boosts during 1757. **Robert Clive** (1725–74) recovered Calcutta for the East India Company (see 1600) and Britain by defeating the Nawab of Bengal at the **Battle of Plassey**. The Holy Roman Emperor **Francis I**—who was married to Austria's Maria Theresa—officially declared war on Prussia. **King Frederick II** then attacked Bohemia, though he was defeated by Austrian troops. Although Prussia defeated Austro-French forces in Rossbach in November, they lost to Austrian troops in Leuthen in December.

In Morocco, **Muhammad III** (c. 1710–90) brought stability to the country as sultan after 30 years of unrest. Muhammad was known for curbing the power of the **Barbary pirates**, who raided towns across the Mediterranean.



Robert Clive

Calcutta was recaptured for the British by Major General Robert Clive at the Battle of Plassey. The victory secured Clive's control over Bengal.

1758



Frederick II leads his soldiers to victory at the Battle of Zorndorf.

AS THE SEVEN YEARS' WAR

CONTINUED, the British won key victories over France by taking **Fort Duquesne** and **Louisbourg** in North America and **Pondicherry** in India (see map, opposite), and by claiming **Senegal** in West Africa. In Europe, Britain and Prussia defeated the French near the banks of the Rhine at **Krefeld** in June and Russia at the battle of **Zorndorf**, on Prussian soil, in August.

Meanwhile, in India, warfare was breaking out on a different front—between Afghans and Marathas. Territorial disputes were behind the **Afghan–Maratha War** (which continued until 1861). After the death of **Nader Shah** (1688–1747), his Persian empire began to disintegrate and Afghanistan emerged independent under the rule of **Ahmad Shah Durrani** (c. 1722–73) who wanted to gain control of the nearby territories of the **Punjab** and the **Upper Ganges**. Durrani had sacked the Mughal city of **Delhi** the previous year. The neighboring Marathas, who felt they should rule over the territory, then went to war against the Afghans.

In the **Arabian Peninsula**, significant—though not violent—political change was taking place as the chieftains of the **Utub** confederation elected **Sabah bin Jaber (Sabah I)** (c. 1652–1762) emir of an emerging territory that would soon become known as **Kuwait**. His family, the al-Sabah dynasty, continues to rule Kuwait to the present day.

1759



Spain's new king, Charles III, would rule for nearly 30 years. Luis Paret y Alcázar (1746–99) depicts palace life in his painting *Charles III Eating Before his Court*.

“ALL IS FOR THE BEST IN THE **BEST OF ALL** POSSIBLE WORLDS.”

Voltaire, French writer, from *Candide*, 1759

FOR THE BRITISH, THE SEVEN YEARS' WAR reached a turning point. They took the French West Indian island of **Guadeloupe** in May, Canadian territory in July, and Quebec in September. They also defeated French naval forces off Portugal at **Lagos Bay** in August and at **Quiberon Bay**, in the west of France, in November. Anglo-Prussian troops defeated the French at the **Battle of Minden** in Germany in early August, although less than two weeks later Prussia faced a humiliating surrender at **Kunersdorf**, in

Germany, followed in November by further defeat by the Austrians in the **Battle of Maxen** in Saxony.

In Spain, the throne was taken by the Bourbon **Charles III** (1716–88), who would become known for his reforming zeal.

Portugal, meanwhile, had grown suspicious of the activities of the Catholic **Jesuit** order (see 1533), expelling it from its territories.

Cultural developments included the publication by the Frenchman **François Marie Arouet de Voltaire** of *Candide*, a satire about mindless optimism.



ABOLITIONISM

The image of a kneeling slave and the inscription “Am I not a man and a brother?” became a famous symbol of the British abolitionist movement and was later adopted by the American Anti-Slavery Society, founded in 1833. The seal was made by Josiah Wedgwood for the Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade. After decades of pressure, the British slave trade ended in 1807. Abolitionist groups were also established in other countries involved in slavery, such as the French *Société des Amis des Noirs*.



Wedgwood pottery

Born into a family of English potters, Josiah Wedgwood transformed his craft with his style and technique. He set up his own business in 1759 and became potter to Queen Charlotte. His “creamware” dishes were hugely popular.

June 23 Lord Clive (1725–74) recovers Calcutta and Bengal.

The Holy Roman Empire (Austria) declares war on Prussia.

August 25 Prussia defeats Russia at **Battle of Zorndorf**.

Afghan–Maratha war begins over disputed territorial claims.

Sabah bin Jaber (1718–62) is elected emir by Utub confederation.

British defeat French at **Fort Duquesne** in American colonies and **Gorée**, **Senegal**, **West Africa**.

French writer and philosopher **Voltaire** (1694–1778) publishes *Candide*.

May Britain captures **Guadeloupe** from France.

August 12 Prussia defeated by Austrian and Prussian forces at the **Battle of Kunersdorf**.

August 1 Anglo-Prussian forces defeat France at the **Battle of Minden**.

September 13 Britain captures **Quebec** from France.

August Charles III (1716–88) takes the Spanish throne.

English potter **Josiah Wedgwood** (1730–95) sets up his own business.

The Royal Botanic Gardens (“Physick Gardens”) at Kew formally established.

November 12 Austria defeats Prussia at the **Battle of Maxen**.

Jesuits are expelled from Portuguese territories.